the thirty features of the *sāmānya-dharma* (the duties of all the people), he specifically states that these are for all men. That is to say, they are not the *dharmas* of any particular group or class or caste of people, but are *sarva-dharma,* i.e., for all men. The *Manu-smṛti,* the Śānti-parva of the *Mahābhārata,* and the *Bhāgavata-purāṇa* abound in similar sentiments.[19]

Socially, in the Indian spirit all people have been regarded as different and separate individuals living their lives as different entities, responsible for their thoughts and practices, and expected to rely on their own efforts toward their betterment and ultimate liberation from bondage. The Indian doctrine of *karma* has had tremendous social effects on the Indian mind. Because of this law, an Indian regards himself as completely responsible for all his deeds. In fact, the Law of Karma is the greatest contribution of the Indian mind in having formulated a truly individualistic attitude vis-à-vis society. It is the most powerful social element of individualism in Hinduism and also in Buddhism. Everyone is exclusively and completely responsible for his or her actions and their consequences. No individual is saved or condemned by any force outside himself—in some schools, not even by God. The Law of Karma is an affirmation, in the strongest terms, of the principle of personal individuality and responsibility.

But, in spite of all this, the existence of slavery of some kind admits of no doubt. Emperor Aśoka (third century B.C.), when proclaiming his law of piety, enjoined that the law of piety consist in kind treatment of slaves and hired servants.[20] In the *Artha-śāstra,* Kauṭilya gives important kindly provisions about slaves.[21] Manu speaks of different kinds of slaves.[22] Malcolm writes that male slaves were "generally treated more like adopted children than menials."[23]

MEDIEVAL PERIOD

Such is the story of the status and dignity of the individual in India in relation to society for about two thousand years of its early history—in the basic and classical texts and in the life of the times. Then came a long period of what is known as India's Medieval Period. India lost its political status and unity. There was no one central authority to legislate for the Indian population as a whole. The country stood divided and separated into hundreds of local or regional kingdoms, all competing and vying with each other to keep their own powers intact. India lost its original spirit of freedom and free enterprise, its earlier outlook; it felt oppressed and